

BOYS BASKETBALL



BRUCE BISHOP/CHRONICLE

Olmited Falls had plenty of support from its student section in Toledo on Thursday night.

Scales, pressure vault 'Dogs

Bob Daniels
The Chronicle-Telegram

TOLEDO — First prize, two trips to Toledo.

It might not sound like much, but Olmited Falls is headed back to the University of Toledo on Saturday night for a Division I regional final date with Toledo St. John's.

It's not Palm Springs, but it puts the Bulldogs in an elite field for the first time since 1997.

They did it with a 68-57 victory over Mansfield Senior on Thursday night in their first season as a Division I school. It was their 22nd victory in 24 games and they achieved it with pressure defense and a game-high 24-point performance by Jamar Scales, which they've been looking for.

But it was the pressure that turned it around for Falls. Coach Pat Donahue said he applied full-court and half-court pressure based on what he learned about the Tygers from scouting reports.

"It's something we saw," said Donahue. "We thought we could get them to turn the ball over a little bit if we pressed the correct way. I thought we had to press the way we did against Southwest (a one-point overtime sectional victory) where instead of just running at the ball, we got them steering the ball toward our traps."

"I thought we were successful, particularly early in the game."

The Bulldogs forced 12 of the Tygers' 19 turnovers in the first half and finished

DIVISION I REGIONAL FINAL

WHO: Olmited Falls (22-2) vs. Toledo St. John's (21-4)

WHEN: Saturday, 7:30 p.m.

WHERE: University of Toledo

TURBIDITY: WDEL 530-AM

NOTABLE: St. John's' dedicated Cleveland Rhodes 60-47 in Thursday's other regional semifinal. The Titans are led by 6-foot-3 guard Brian Roberts (17.5 points per game) and 6-6 post B.J. Raymond (18.6 ppg).

with 21 total points off turnovers. Mansfield scored six points off turnovers.

"Another thing we thought we needed to do against this team was mix things up a little bit defensively," said Donahue.

"We switched into a couple of zone presses and played a little half-court zone just to see if we could do that."

They could and Scales, for one, liked the outcome.

"I feel that we're coming along better as a team defensively," said Scales. "We're crashing the boards more and we're moving the ball more. We're coming together."

That included the offense.

Scales, Steve Gansey with 21 points and Dan Buggell with 13, combined to score 64 of the Bulldogs' points. The other four came from Corey Sparks.

Gansey drained the definitive shot, a long 3-pointer from the left side with 2:51

to play. It gave the Bulldogs their biggest lead to that point, 64-53.

"I think it was Dan who tossed me the ball and the defender was a couple feet off me," said Gansey. "You know, I'm no stranger to shooting a three so I just shot it and it went in. It got us up by 11."

Bingelli said the Tygers reminded him a little of Southwest.

"They were definitely as athletic as Southwest was," Bingelli said. "They had a lot of quick guards. We couldn't really play too much defense on them. When we got them in the zone (press), we started to do a little better, but they still beat us to the hole."

The Bulldogs are just a victory away from unexplored territory — a trip to Columbus and a berth in the Final Four.

"These guys just want to keep playing," Donahue said. "This has been a goal of ours since well before the season began. We've put ourselves in a situation to achieve that goal Saturday night."

"All you can ask for is an opportunity. We have the opportunity. We're going to come out Saturday and see how we handle it."

Notes

■ Gansey's brother and former Bulldogs star Mike Gansey watched the game from the Olmited Falls bench. Mike Gansey sat out this basketball season after transferring to West Virginia from St. Xavier.

■ Among the spectators were Keystone coach Greg Morgan and some members of his staff.

■ The Olmited Falls student section, resplendent in all manner of blue-and-gold

Boys results

THURSDAY'S RESULTS

CIN. MIDDLE 64 Cate 44/MS 20
CIN. COLLEGE 69 Bedford 34
HAMILTON 65 Cate 34/Spartan 54
OLMITED FALLS 68 Mansfield 57
ST. JOHN'S 61 Cate 34/Lakeview 25
ST. JOHN'S 61 Cate 34/Lakeview 25
CIN. FALLS 60 Cate 34/Lakeview 25
CLARK 72 Hopkins 62
CHESAPE 50 Johnson 43
CIN. TOWNSHIP 54 Piquette 40
CAYUGA FALLS 40 Cate 34/Lakeview 25
LAKESIDE 60 Bedford 34
LAUREL 40 Cate 34/Lakeview 25
ST. HENRY 51 Bedford 34/Lakeview 25
VERMILION 51 Bloom-Cornell 43

FALLS

From B1

last year and this year. It's been a big goal of ours."

The win was the Bulldogs' 14th in a row. In many of the previous encounters it was the offense that led the way, but in recent outings the defense has come up big. Such was the case Saturday.

The Bulldogs press — or rather presses — forced the Tygers into 19 turnovers, which the Bulldogs turned into 21 points. Meanwhile Mansfield (17-7) cashed in just six points off nine Falls miscues.

"The press has been our Achilles' heel all year," said Mansfield coach Gregg Collins. "We've had trouble with the press and lost numerous leads. The pressure has been the cause of that."

"We saw in our (scouting) report that we thought we could get them to turn the ball over. We steered them into the traps, then jumped it that way," Donahue said.

The full-court press forced five straight turnovers in the first quarter and led directly to four Olmited Falls baskets as the Bulldogs went from an 8-3 deficit into a 15-8 lead in less than two minutes.

Scales led the way with 14 of his game-high 24 points in the first quarter. He had three of his four steals in the first eight minutes. Even where Mansfield had the edge — on the backboards — it failed to capitalize. The Tygers ruled the glass 42-28 and had 17 offensive rebounds, but outscored the Bulldogs only 12-11 on second-chance points.

"Tonight we struggled to finish," said Mansfield's Collins.

"When the Tygers tried taking the ball to the basket, the Bulldogs collapsed in the middle and forced them into tough shots. Mansfield did sink 44.8 percent of its shots, but made only one 3-pointer and was 4-for-10 from the line.

"We needed the (defensive) wings to pinch in quickly," Donahue said. "We had to have guys get early help. In the second half we did a much better job helping off on the wings."

Olmited Falls led 38-32 at halftime,



BRUCE BISHOP/CHRONICLE

Falls senior point guard Mickey Mantal goes over the scores' table chasing after a loose ball Thursday night in the Bulldogs' victory.

even though Bingelli got a late start.

He didn't score in the first quarter, but put up 10 of his 18 points in the second period.

The Bulldogs, too, struggled from the 3-point line, making only 4-of-22. Pat Braddock, who torched St. Ed's for 25 points in the district title game, couldn't get one to fall and was blanked.

But Olmited Falls was deadly on its 2-point shot attempts, making 21-of-32 for 65.6 percent. Mansfield, meanwhile, couldn't get the lead.

"A couple of times we got it to four and then they would make big plays when they needed to," Collins said. "This team has a lot of scoring weapons. That's something we didn't see much of this year."

After the 12-point burst in the first quarter, Olmited Falls was in front the rest of the way, although the lead was never safe. Falls led for the last 28:46 of the 32-minute game, but the lead didn't top 10 points until Gansey nailed a 3-

pointer with 2:51 left to play to push the margin to 64-53.

Mansfield, which trailed 59-53 moments before, went three minutes without a point, missing the first of a one-and-one and then a pair of two-shot fouls.

Meanwhile Scales sank two from the line and so did Gansey. Falls had a 13-point lead twice in the last 38 minutes. "I'm very impressed with Olmited Falls," said Collins. "They play awfully hard and they're disciplined. The seniors showed they're veterans."

MANSFIELD 57: Marquis Carter 8-16, Brandon Smith 10-12, Richard Reed 1-2, Trent Owsen 2-10, Jon Avery 4-10, Jamal Sutton 3-10, Jason Boyd 1-10, Dennis Boyd 0-0, Andrew Hickey 1-10, Kyle Salsbery 0-0, Monte Young 0-0. **OLMITED FALLS 68:** Dan Buggell 6-13, Pat Braddock 0-0, Jack Salsbery 0-0, Clayton Lawrence 0-0, Eric Hock 0-0, Steve Gansey 10-12, Mickey Mantal 10-18, Alan Roush 0-0, Jason Tabor 0-0, Tyler Spivey 0-0. **TEAMS**
Mansfield 18 14 13 12 — 57
Falls 18 18 18 18 — 68
Three-pointers: Mansfield 1-6 (Boyd) Olmited Falls 4-23 (Gansey 2, Braddock 2, Scales 2) Rebounds: Mansfield 42 Olmited Falls 21, Olmited Falls 20 (Scales 6), Turnovers: Mansfield 12 Olmited Falls 9 Fouls: Olmited Falls 15 Olmited Falls 13 Fouls off: Home: Free Throws: Mansfield 4-10 (40 percent) Olmited Falls 14-20 (70 percent) Field Goals: Mansfield 26-54 (48 percent), Olmited Falls 25-54 (46 percent)

GIRLS BASKETBALL



MEET THE ALL-STARS

The Chronicle-Telegram, along with the county girls and boys coaches associations, is a proud co-sponsor of the Lucas County girls and boys senior basketball all-star games. Tickets are available at the door the night of the game or at county schools.

SENIOR GIRLS ALL-STAR GAMES

★ Sunday, March 28, at Avon High School
Game 1 at 6 p.m., Game 2 at 8 p.m.
2004 Ms. Basketball Award will be announced between games

25th annual GENE LEGEZA CLASSIC

★ BOYS ALL-STAR GAMES
Sunday, April 4, at Avon High School
Game 1 at 6 p.m., Game 2 at 8 p.m.
2004 Mr. Basketball Award will be announced between games

AVON LAKE

Molly Baker

Parents: Pam and Mike Baker
Varsity Letters: Overall — 6, Basketball — 3
2003-04 Statistics: Field-goal percentage — 42.8, Four-shooting percentage — 47.4, Average rebounds — 3.4, Average assists — 1.7, Total points — 235, Average points — 12.4, Career points — 515
College plans: Plans to attend Ohio Wesleyan (undecided on major)

Erica Morrison

Parents: Cecilia and Dean Monson
Varsity Letters: Overall — 5, Basketball — 3
2003-04 Statistics: Field-goal percentage — 39.5, Four-shooting percentage — 62.2, Average rebounds — 3.4, Average assists — 2.1, Total points — 144, Average points — 7.6, Career points — 443
College plans: Plans to attend Misericordia and study physical therapy

Kelly Miller

Parents: Amy and Mark Miller
Varsity Letters: Overall — 4, Basketball — 3
2003-04 Statistics: Field-goal percentage — 58.9, Four-shooting percentage — 61.5, Average rebounds — 5.5, Average assists — 0.4, Total points — 159, Average points — 8.3, Career points — 443
College plans: Undecided

ELYRIA CATHOLIC

Kileen Lehman

Parents: Dan and Kathleen Lehman
Varsity Letters: Overall — 10, Basketball — 3
2003-04 — Field-goal percentage — 40, Four-shooting percentage — 32.4, Average rebounds — 3.6, Average assists — 1.0, Total points — 84, Average points — 4.4, Career points — unavailable
College plans: Undecided

Stephanie Tanner

Parents: Jeff and Vicki Tanner
Varsity Letters: Overall — 7, Basketball — 3
2003-04 Statistics: Field-goal percentage — 43.3, Four-shooting percentage — 74.2, Average rebounds — 5.5, Average assists — 3.0, Total points — 212, Average points — 16.3, Career points — unavailable
College plans: Undecided

FINAL FOUR

Badin off to finals

The Associated Press

COLUMBUS — Kym Fiehrer scored the tying layup in regulation and the go-ahead layup in overtime, her only baskets in Hamilton Badin's 54-50 win over Salem in a Division II girls' state semifinal Thursday night.

Fiehrer gave herself the chance to drive for the winning score in OT, saving a backcourt violation by snaring an errant pass near the midcourt line.

Her basket put the Rams (22-5) ahead 52-50 with 31.2 seconds to play. She was fouled but missed the free throw for a three-point lead.

The Quakers (25-2) turned the ball over with 6 seconds to play, and Caitlin Beckett made two free throws to seal Badin's trip to the state finals.

Fiehrer's first basket, also a driving layup, tied the score 46-46 with 50 seconds to play in regulation. Badin immediately got the ball back when Fiehrer intercepted a deflected pass, but Beckett missed a 3-pointer.

Salem had a last chance in regulation with 11.3 seconds to play, Lizzie Jesko dribbled down the court and found Renee Farina in the left corner, but she missed her jumper.

The Rams will try for their first state championship since 1999 and second overall on Saturday against Beloit West Branch. The Warriors defeated Therville Sheridan 57-44 in the earlier Division II semifinal.

Beloit W. Branch 57, Therville Sheridan 44

Amber Armstrong scored 16 points and Ashley Anderson added 10 points and 12 rebounds and Evelyn Woods had eight points and 10 rebounds for the Warriors (25-1), who will play in their first state championship game.

Darcy Williams led the Generals (24-2) with 13 points, Jessie Slack scored nine and Amanda Kroft had eight. Offensive rebounds helped West

Branch overcome poor shooting. Nothing could save Sheridan's offense, which had 18 turnovers and only six assists.

The Generals didn't get a basket for the final 2:01 of the first quarter, the entire 6-minute second quarter and the first 3:06 of the third — a span of 13:07.

They shot an abysmal 4-for-18 in the first half and trailed 15-for-42. Sheridan scored all seven of its second-quarter points on free throws and trailed 24-15 at the half.

West Branch had 10 offensive rebounds in the first half, converting them into easy layups and putbacks. The Warriors only hit 8 of 28 shots before halftime, but seven of the baskets came in the paint.

West Branch led 32-16 when Kroft drove for a layup with 4:54 remaining in the third quarter — Sheridan's first basket since Steve Large's 15-foot jumper with 2:01 remaining in the first.

Oak Hill 70, Smithville 50
The highest scoring team at the girls' state basketball tournament in Columbus didn't disappoint — at least for one quarter.

Oak Hill set a record for a Division III semifinal with nine 3-pointers, tying the previous mark of eight in the first quarter.

Alyssa Hammond, the Division III co-player of the year, led the Oaks (25-1) with 25 points. She hit 9-of-14 shots from the field, 3-of-5 from 3-point range and 4-of-6 free throws.

Alison Hill led the Smiths (24-3) with 14 points and Beth Buchwater added 13. The Oaks, whose 75.0 points per game average topped the 16-team tournament field, finished 9-for-18 behind the arc, shot 24-for-43 from the field and went 13-for-14 at the foul line.

They also led the Division II semifinal record for points in a quarter while taking a 30-17 lead after one. Oak Hill won the second 11 points in each of the next two periods, but still led 52-41 after three.

Youngstown Ursuline 59, Plain City Jonathan Alder 43
Rebecca Slatery scored 17 points and Youngstown Ursuline took advantage of Plain City Jonathan Alder's foul trouble in a Division III state girls' semifinal Thursday in Columbus.

Courtney Davidson, the division's co-player of the year, led 16 points and 12 rebounds for the Fighting Hill (25-2), who will play in their first state championship game.

All-state selection Lauren Prochaska led the Pioneers (25-2) with 21 points, but was limited by what she could do after getting called for her fourth foul with 57.3 seconds remaining in the first half.